



Games, but, on the flip side, it also adds to the already impressive amount of exposure the team desperately needs to do well on the world stage. Add the fact that it will be back in the Pro League in the upcoming season, and exposure is one area the women cannot complain about.

In fact, the number of international matches the Indian teams played throughout 2023 was one of the biggest positives. For a long time, the lack of exposure has been cited as a reason for India's failure to break through on the world stage. In 2023, India played the maximum number of matches among all the top nations, both men and women — 36 for the men and 24 for the women — with an identical 66.67 per cent win percentage (24 for men and 16 for women).

The other common factor between the men's and women's teams is their clear superiority in the continent and contrasting struggles against teams from outside. If the men have repeatedly proven they are now miles ahead of the other Asian sides, the women, too, are among the best on the continent. But it is in Europe that

Mercurial challengers:

Harmanpreet Singh's Team India is poetry in motion, flourishing when everything falls into place but can as easily slip into a cacophony of discordant notes. PTI

their biggest challenge lies. The Indian women played against Germany, the Netherlands, Spain, and Australia in preparation for the Asian Games. But while they may have learned their lessons, they were unable to get victories. The five-nation event in December saw them lose to Spain, Germany, and Belgium, with a lone win against Ireland. The men too, while not completely outplayed, have been less than impressive; in the same tournament, India lost 7-2 to Belgium.

A bigger concern will be the inability of the junior teams, both men and women, to throw up too many challengers to the established names on the national team. The juniors both won the Asia Cup, but while the men finished fourth at the Junior World Cup for the second consecutive time, the women



Highlights of 2023

Men

Won the Asian Champions Trophy and the Asian Games
Finished **3rd** in **2022-23** Pro League
Finished **3rd** in world rankings
Hardik Singh named FIH Player of the Year

Women

Won the Asian Champions Trophy
Bronze at the Asian Games
Achieved highest-ever rank of **6th** position
Savita named FIH Goalkeeper of the Year

Junior men

Won Junior Asia Cup
4th at Sultan of Johor Cup
4th at Junior World Cup

Junior women

Won Junior Asia Cup